With no positive response from the Centre after repeatedly flagging the matter, the TMC has decided to weaponise the obstruction of NREGS and PMAY-G funds against the BJP ahead of the Lok Sabha polls, just as it did in the panchayat polls in July. On October 2 and 3, TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee was in Delhi with a large contingent of MPs, MLAs, zilla parishad, panchayat samiti chiefs and 'victims of deprivation'. On October 2, they held a sit-in demonstration demanding the release of funds before the police forced them to move out. The next day, they held a protest at Jantar Mantar and later sought a meeting with Union minister of state for rural development Sadhvi Niranjan Jyoti, but couldn't get an appointment. Meanwhile, the BJP kept up its attacks on the TMC. Giriraj Singh said that the misappropriation of funds under the social schemes in Bengal must face a CBI inquiry. Adhikari, who was in Delhi and who met Jyoti hours before the TMC delegation turned up said, "I have requested the MoS for a CBI investigation. Fake job card holders conspiring with TMC leaders and the bureaucracy have made away with Rs 5,000-Rs 7,000 crore of the Rs 54,150 crore that the Centre sent Bengal in the past nine years," Adhikari said later.

Back in Bilkanda, on being asked why her dues haven't been met, Arati says, "It is a political tussle and we are being crushed under its weight."

THE PMAY-G TANGLE

Arati's neighbour Ramesh Mandal, 54, is concerned about when the money sanctioned under the PMAY-G will be credited to his bank account. Ramesh, too, used to make a living from NREGS jobs and drives an auto-rickshaw to earn a living. "I live in my son's house. I don't want to be a liability. This is why I need my house," Ramesh says.

The Centre stopped payments to Bengal under the PMAY-G since November-December 2022. Yet, during the same period, it had allowed the state to sanction 1,136,488 new houses. The state finalised a list of 1,101,742 houses. Senior officials of the state panchayat department said that the Union government owes Rs 8,141.17 crore as its contribution under the PMAY-G to Bengal. In anticipation that the Centre will release its funds, the state has released around Rs 133 crore, the first installment of its total projected contribution of Rs 5,427 crore. The PMAY-G expenses are shared by the Centre and the states in a 60:40 ratio.

THE CENTRE ALLEGES INELIGIBLE PEOPLE ARE ALLOTTED **HOUSES, KEEPING OUT ELIGIBLE ONES** IN THE PMAY-G SCHEME

The Centre had two primary allegations regarding irregularities in the PMAY-G scheme in Bengal. Firstly, they alleged that ineligible people are accorded houses, whereas eligible names were deleted from the lists. The allegation, again spearheaded by BJP's Adhikari, was that TMC leaders had cornered the benefits of PMAY-G. Secondly, the Centre alleged that the state had changed the name of the scheme to Banglar Bari Awas Yojana and was unwilling to use the PMAY-G logo.

In the past year, 69 central teams have visited Bengal to investigate allegations of malpractices under PMAY-G. The past 10 teams were headed by officers of joint secretary rank, who carried out a probe between April 9 and 16, 2023. Faced with the teams' findings, the state was forced to conduct an internal enquiry and admit in December 2022 that 1.7 million ineligible people made it to the PMAY beneficiary list. This was because, by 2022, the economic condition of those beneficiaries had improved, say officials.

"We have made rectifications and lodged FIRs as directed. The last 10 teams have sent us no report. One presumes this means that they did not find anything adverse," a state official says.

According to TMC Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, the "majority" of the shortcomings pointed out by the central probe teams in both NREGS and PMAY-G have been rectified. Still, the funds have not been released, "definitely to give recognition to the wild allegations of the state BJP unit and "to create an economic blockade, with an eye on the Lok Sabha election". ■

SQUABBLE OVER TWO SCHEMES

The TMC government in Bengal and the Centre are in a tussle over two flagship Central programmes

- **WAGES ACCRUED** till December 2021 under NREGS are frozen by the Union government
- **THE CENTRE** also stopped payments to Bengal under the PMAY-G since November-December 2022
- **ACTION IN BOTH** cases were taken due to allegations of widespread corruption
- **MULTIPLE CENTRAL** teams have visited Bengal and probed the alleged NREGS irregularities since 2021
- **IN THE LAST ONE** year, 69 Central teams have investigated allegations of malpractices under PMAY-G
- **A STATE** government probe found 17 lakh PMAY beneficiaries were ineligible as their economic condition had improved
- **BENGAL** government says funds are stuck despite meeting Centre's demands, alleges 'vendetta politics'